Definition of Nutrition

Nutrition is the process of ingestion, digestion, absorption, transportation and utilization of nutrients for the well being of the body. It is the process of providing nourishment to the body for a healthy life.

DO YOU KNOW...?

Nutrition science is the area of knowledge regarding the role of food in maintenance of health.

Optimum nutrition is required to maintain good health. There are certain signs of good nutrition. In addition, nutrition is concerned with social, economic, cultural and psychological implications of food and eating.

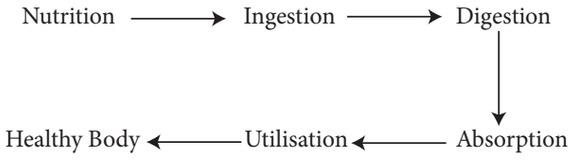


Fig 8.3: Nutrition and Health

Thus we understand that "Nutrition functionally means food at work".

Functions of Nutrition: The two main functions of nutrition are:

1. To provide material for growth and repair of tissues that eventually maintains the basic structure of our body.
2. To support the body with the energy required to perform all metabolic activities.

Nutritional Status

Nutrients are essential elements required for the normal functioning of our body. Nutrients when taken in excess or its deficiency results in over nutrition, malnutrition and under nutrition.

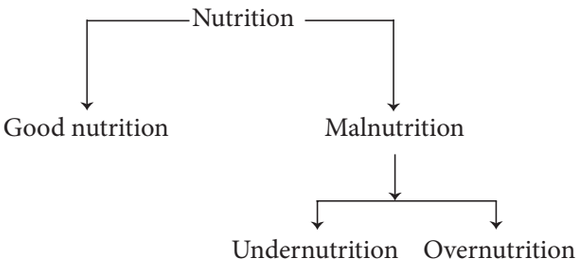


Fig 8.4: Nutritional Status

Good nutrition: "Good nutrition is the state in which a person gets all the nutrients required in correct amounts and proportion and some nutrients are stored in the body after meeting all the body requirements". This is known as optimum or adequate nutrition and it helps to maintain good health. Thus nutrients from food sources enable one to keep fit and maintain health. These substances include energy which gives the capacity to work, proteins which form our body muscles, bones, blood, organs, skin, hair and nervous tissues. Food supplies minerals and vitamins which protect our organs and regulate their functions and other physiological processes.

Malnutrition: Malnutrition is that state of ill-health which may be caused by the deficiency or excess of one or more essential nutrients in the body. Unhealthy environment also causes malnutrition. Physical, mental and intellectual well-being of a person is affected due to malnourishment.

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